For Colored Girls Who Have Considered Suicide

By Ntozake Shange (En-toe-ZAK-kay SHONG-gay)

INTRODUCTION

Let me take you back to the late 60's/early 70s and just how difficult it was to be a black female at the time. Facing hardships and continuing to survive despite horrific experiences, being black as well as female placed these women in a double minority. In For Colored Girls Who Have Considered Suicide, Ntozake Shange shares the good and bad personal experiences of women of color. First to share her perspective is the Lady in Blue . . .

Character: Lady in Blue

i'm outside manhattan

i used ta live in the world
then i moved to HARLEM
& my universe is now six blocks

when i walked in the pacific
i imagined waters ancient from accra/ tunis
cleansing me/ feeding me
now my ankles are coated in grey filth
from the puddle near the hydrant

my oceans were life
what waters i have here sit stagnant
circling ol men's bodies
& broken lil whiskey bottles
left to make me bleed

iusedta live in the world
now i live in harlem & my universe is six blocks
a tunnel with a small train
ican ride anywhere
remaining a stranger

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icd stay alone
a woman in the world
then i moved to
HARLEM
icome in at dusk
stay close to the curb

wdnt be good
not good at all
to meet a tall short black brown young man fulla his power
in the dark
in my universe of six blocks

iusedta live in the world
really be in the world
free & sweet talkin
good mornin & thank-you & nice day
uh-huh
ican't now
ican't be nice to nobody
nice is such a rip-off
reglar beauty & a smile in the street
is just a set-up

ihadda right to the world
then i moved to harlem for the set-up
a universe
six blocks of cruelty
piled up on itself
a tunnel
closin

we deal wit emotion too much
so why dont we go on ahead & be white then/
&make everythin dry & abstract wit no rhythm & no
reelin for sheer sensual pleasure/yes let's go on
&be white/ we're right in the middle of it/ no use
holdin out/ holdin onto ourselves/ lets think our
way outta feelin/ let's abstract ourselves some families
&thinkin wont do me a bit of
good tonite/ i need to be loved/ & havent the audacity

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to say
where you are/ & dont know who to say it to

one thing i dont need
is anymore apologies
igot sorry greetin me at my front door
you can keep yrs
idont know what to do wit em
they dont open doors
or bring the sun back
they dont make me happy
or get a mornin paper
didnt nobody stop usin my tears to wash cars
cuz a sorry

iam simply tired
of collectin
    i didnt know
    i was so important to you'
i'm gonna haveta throw some away
icant get to the clothes in my closet
for alla sorries
i'm gonna tack a sign to my door
leave a message by the phone
        'if you called
        to say yr sorry
        call somebody
        else
        i dont use em anymore'
ilet sorry/ didnt meanta/ & how cd i know abt that
take a walk down a dark & musty street in brooklyn
i'm gonna do exactly what i want to
&i wont be sorry for none of it
letta sorry soothe yr soul/
i'm gonna soothe mine

you were always inconsistent
doin somethin & then bein sorry
beatin my heart to death
talkin bout you sorry
well

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iwill not call
i'm not going to be nice
iwill raise my voice
&scream & holler
&break things & race the engine
&tell all yr secrets about yrself to your face
&i will list in detail everyone of my wonderful lovers
&their ways
&i wont be sorry for none of it

iloved you on purpose
iwas open on purpose
istill crave vulnerability & close talk
& i'm not even sorry bout you bein sorry
you can carry all the guilt & grime ya wanna
just dont give it to me
icant use another sorry
next time
you should admit
you're mean/ lowdown /trifin/ & no count straight out
steada being sorry alla the time
enjoy being yrself

ifound god in myself
&i loved her/ i loved her fiercely

& this is for colored girls who have considered
suicide/ but are movin to the ends of their own
rainbows

TRANSITION

While the Lady in Blue struggles to adjust to a life in Harlem, surrounded by values and a society very different from what she has known . . . While she struggles to come to terms with what she is willing to accept and what she wants for herself , The Lady in Yellow relates a quite different reality: The celebration of her graduation from high school . . .

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CHARACTER: Lady in Yellow

it was graduation nite & i waz the only virgin in the crowd
bobby mills martin jerome & sammy yates eddie jones & randi
all cousins
all the prettiest niggers in this factory town
carried me out wit em
in a deep black buick
smellin of thunderbird & ladies in heat
we rambled from camden to mount holly
laughin at the afternoon's speeches
& danglin our tassles from the rear view mirror
climbin different sorta project stairs
movin toward snappin beer cans &
GET IT GET IT THAT'S THE WAY TO DO IT MAMA
all mercer county graduated the same nite
cosmetology secretarial pre-college autoshop & business
all us movin from mama to what ever waz out there
that nite we raced a big ol truck from the barbeque stand
trying to tell him bout the party at jacqui's
where folks graduated last year waz waitin to hit it wid us
i got drunk & cdnt figure out
whose hand waz on my thigh/but it didn't matter
cuz these cousins martin eddie sammy jerome & bobby
waz my sweethearts alternately since the seventh grade
& everybody knew i always started cryin if somebody actually
tried to take advantage of me
at jacqui's
ulinda mason was stickin her mouth all out
while we tumbled out the buick
eddie jones waz her lickin stick
but i knew how to dance
it got soo hot
vincent ramos puked all in the punch
& harly jumped all in tico's face
cuz he was leavin for the navy in the mornin
hadda kick *** so we'd all remember how bad he waz
seems like sheila & marguerite waz fraid
to get their hair turnin back
so they laid up against the wall

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lookin almost sexy
didnt wanna sweat
but me & my fellas
we waz dancin
since 1963 i'd won all kinda contests
wid the cousins at the POLICE ATHLETIC LEAGUE DANCES
all mercer county knew
any kin to martin yates cd turn somersaults
fore smokey robinson cd get a woman excited
we danced
doin nasty ol tricks i'd been thinkin since may
cuz graduation nite had to be hot
& i waz the only virgin
so i hadda make like my hips waz inta some business
that way everybody thot whoever was gettin it
was a older man cdnt run the streets wit youngsters
martin slipped his leg round my thigh
the dells bumped "stay"
up & down-up & down the new carver homes
WE WAZ GROWN
WE WAZ FINALLY GROWN
ulinda alla sudden went crazy
went over to eddie cursin & carryin on
tearin his skin wid her nails
the cousins tried to talk sense to her
tried to hold her arms
lissin **** sammy went on
bobby whispered i shd go wit him
fore they go ta cuttin
fore the police arrived
we teetered silently thru the parkin lot
no un uhuh
we didn't know nothin bout no party
bobby started lookin at me
yeah
he started looking at me real strange
like i waz a woman or somethin/
started talkin real soft
in the backseat of that ol buick
WOW

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TRANSITION

And although every black women has her own unique experience, they also are united by their color and gender in a world that too often marginalized their existence. The Lady in Brown makes a final plea for black women in America. Listen carefully, for humanity unites us all.

CHARACTER: Lady in Brown

dark phrases of womanhood
of never havin been a girl
half-notes scattered
without rhythm/no tune
distraught laughter fallin
over a black girl's shoulder
it's funny/it's hysterical
the melody-less-ness of her dance
don't tell nobody don't tell a soul
she's dancin on beer cans & shingles
this must be the spook house
another song with no singers
lyrics/no voices
& interrupted solos
unseen performances
are we ghouls?
children of horror?
the joke?
don't tell nobody don't tell a soul
are we animals? have we gone crazy?
i can't hear anythin
but maddening screams
& the soft strains of death
& you promised me
you promised me...
somebody/anybody
sing a black girl's song
bring her out
to know herself

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to know you
but sing her rhythms
carin/struggle/hard times
sing her song of life
she's been dead so long
closed in silence so long
she doesn't know the sound
of her own voice
her infinite beauty
she's half-notes scattered
without rhythm/no tune
sing her sighs
sing the song of her possibilities
sing a righteous gospel
let her be born
let her be born
& handled warmly.
& this is for colored girls who have considered suicide
but moved to the ends of their own rainbows.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ntozake Shange
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AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
Ohio State Qualifier

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